PRAMOD PUSHKARNA



DEVI LAL

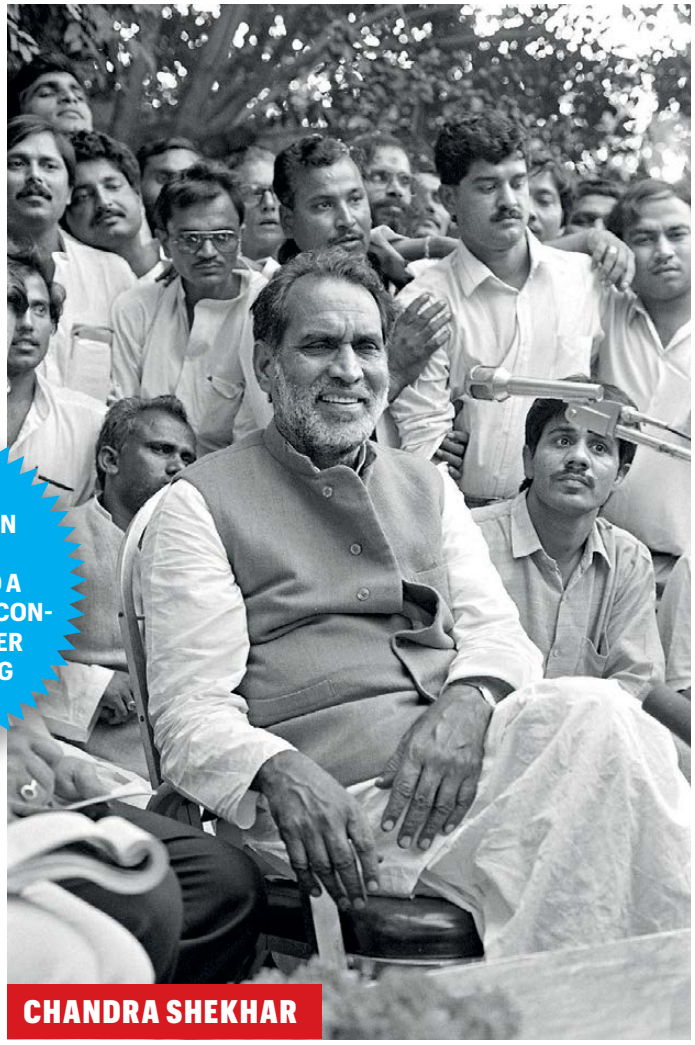
When history repeats itself, sometimes tragedy and farce are ladled out in equal proportion across its many instalments. So it certainly seems to be the case with the great Janata experiment—the 'third way' in Indian politics that seemed most efficient at losing its way around the multiple roundabouts of Lutyens' Delhi. The shambolic trial run of 1977-80 was still fresh in everyone's mind, so the Janata Dal of the late 1980s had in front of it a first-rate manual of what *not* to do. Yet, the second edition went right ahead and reprinted those bloomers anyway. Within the compressed time-frame he got on the main stage of history, V.P. Singh managed to unleash a social revolution.

VP had emerged from within the Congress as the conscientious dissenter on Bofors, the new 'Mr Clean', and the old Janata fragments coalesced around him. But he had to contend with his own pair of sulking wannabes—the Jat farmer-patriarch Devi Lal, almost a rerun of Charan Singh in 1977, and the brooding 'Young Turk' Chandra Shekhar. The first was mollified with deputy prime ministership, then checkmated with Mandal.

Nothing worked with the second malcontent, though. Chandra Shekhar, who had rediscovered the *padayatra* for modern Indian politics, walked out of the VP government. There was another axis of instability: the BJP's outside support. The partnership had proved costly in the 1970s, too, but anti-Congressism was still strong enough to produce one more iteration of that co-

CHANDRA SHEKHAR'S REIGN STARTED WITH JUST 64 MPs AND A LIFELINE FROM THE CONGRESS. THE LATTER PULLED THE PLUG SOON ENOUGH

SHARAD SAXENA



CHANDRA SHEKHAR